

The 5 Mistakes That Shut Down the Conversation Before It Starts

You want to talk to someone you love about their substance use. Here's what derails that conversation in the first 30 seconds — and what to do instead.

1. Picking the wrong moment

The worst mistake isn't in the words — it's in the timing. Bringing it up when they've been drinking, when you're angry, or in front of other people guarantees one thing: defensiveness. A conversation that starts defensive is already over.

Do this instead: wait for a calm, private, sober moment — even if that means waiting three days. The conversation you don't ruin is worth more than the one you force tonight.

2. Diagnosing instead of describing

"You have a drinking problem" is a verdict. And people defend themselves against verdicts. They'll fight the label instead of hearing the concern — and you'll spend the whole conversation debating a word instead of talking about what's actually happening.

Do this instead: describe one specific fact. "I've noticed you've been drinking more at dinner these past few months." An observed fact is almost impossible to argue with.

3. Accusing with "you" instead of speaking with "I"

"You're ruining everything," "you're always drunk," "you're embarrassing us" — every "you" is an attack, and attacks trigger counterattacks. The conversation becomes a fight, and the fight becomes their proof that the real problem is you.

Do this instead: "I get scared when you drive after drinking." Nobody can argue with what YOU feel.

4. Emptying the whole bag at once

Years of incidents, dates, and accumulated proof — dumped all at once, it feels like a trial. And people defend themselves in trials. Every extra example hands them one more thing to dispute, minimize, or turn back on you.

Do this instead: pick ONE specific, recent fear. A single true thing that's hard to deny weighs more than thirty accusations.

5. Demanding the full solution immediately

"Go to rehab" as the only acceptable outcome is asking someone in denial to jump off a roof. Refusal is almost guaranteed — and then you have no next step. The conversation ends on a no, and the silence takes over for months.

Do this instead: one small, concrete ask. "Can you just talk to your doctor about it?" or "Will you actually think about it?" Small asks get yeses — and a first yes changes everything.

The next step: the exact words, for YOUR situation

Avoiding the mistakes is half the job. The other half is knowing what to say — to your spouse, your son, your mother, with your history and what's really happening at home. TheFirstWord builds your personalized letter, conversation guide and spoken script in under 60 seconds. From \$9, with a 7-day money-back guarantee.

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